Metal utensils: HMTc Standard

Karen Pendergrass · · Heavy Metal Tested & Certified, Institute of Contaminant Standards

CITE AS

Pendergrass K. "Metal utensils: HMTc Standard". Heavy Metal Certified, 2026. https://heavymetalcertified.com/standards/utensils-metal. CC BY 4.0.

CORRESPONDENCE

Corrections are logged publicly on the article page, each with its date, the affected value, and the source that resolved it.

KEYWORDS

heavy metals, food safety, dietary exposure

PUBLICATION HISTORY

This revision 2026-08.

Abstract

The Heavy Metal Tested & Certified heavy-metal-safety standard for metal utensils in Food-Contact Consumer Goods and Kitchenware, evaluated on element RELEASE FROM THE FOOD-CONTACT ALLOY INTO FOOD OR A FOOD SIMULANT, µg/kg of food, determined against an acidic simulant at the article's stated use temperature and duration with the third successive release governing for repeat-use articles. This is a RELEASE basis on the food, not the plastics-simulant convention and not a total-content basis: the percent-by-weight lead limits on food-contact metals and solder are a separate MATERIAL-CONTENT obligation, disclosed as companions and never published here.. No government sets a numeric heavy-metal limit for this product form, so every panel analyte is held under mandatory analytical control or a substantiated not-material determination rather than an invented ceiling.

1 | How every number on this standard is set

HMTc Method v2.0 (government-limit-only): the strictest applicable sovereign maximum for this exact product form expressed as specific element migration into food or a food simulant; a disclosed read-across from the nearest applicable sovereign value in the same basis where the food-contact material family is expressly excluded from or not reached by that instrument; a substantiated not-material determination; or a control. No cell is occurrence-derived, and no cell borrows a value across a basis.

2 | Master limit table

All values in ppb (µg/kg), as_sold basis. A brand meeting every value qualifies for the mark.

ANALYTE	TIER	HMTC LIMIT	BASIS

Lead (Pb)	Tier 1	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum
Cadmium (Cd)	Tier 1	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum
Total arsenic (tAs)	Tier 2	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum
Inorganic arsenic (iAs)	Tier 1	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum
Mercury, total (tHg)	Tier 1	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum
Methylmercury (MeHg)	Tier 1	n/m	not material in this matrix
Nickel (Ni)	Tier 2	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum
Tin (Sn)	Tier 2	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum
Aluminium (Al)	Tier 2	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum
Total chromium (Cr)	Tier 2	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum
Hexavalent chromium (Cr-VI)	Tier 2	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum

3 | Derivation — where each number comes from

Every cell traces to one named sovereign maximum level (the strictest for the nearest analog), or to an explicit control, not-material, or species-bounded determination. No occurrence statistic selects a certification value.

ANALYTE	HMTC	SOVEREIGN ANALOG / DETERMINATION

Lead (Pb)	control	No credible sovereign sets a numeric ceiling on element release from a metal or alloy food-contact article. Regulation (EU) 10/2011 governs plastics only; metals and alloys are a separate Regulation 1935/2004 Annex I material family for which the EU has adopted no specific measure, the US regulates food-contact substances without an element release ceiling, and Codex, FSANZ, Health Canada, the UK and Hong Kong set none. Testing is therefore mandatory on every certified lot with no invented ceiling: a limit borrowed from the plastics regulation would be a limit written for a different material family, and for an alloy surface the plastics nickel and aluminium values are not even achievable, so borrowing them would be an unfounded number rather than a stricter one. Lead in a food-contact metal article arrives from the alloy, from lead-bearing solder and brazing at joints and base plugs, and from plated or printed decoration on the interior. Japan Notice 370 (1959) and Korea MFDS Notice 2024-29 do set sovereign lead limits for food-contact metals, but they are percent-by-weight limits on the metal, solder and tin plating: a MATERIAL-CONTENT basis. Both jurisdictions also sit OUTSIDE the HMTc credible-regulator set used for anchoring in this build, so they could not supply a published number here even in the right basis; they are disclosed as real foreign obligations and must not be promoted to anchors without a recorded governance ruling. That obligation is disclosed as a companion and is verified on every certified article; it is not published as this row's release ceiling, because a content limit and a release limit are different measured quantities. For hollow-handle flatware the binding component is the handle-joint filler or solder, not the bowl alloy; for plated utensils it is the exposed substrate at a worn area.

Cadmium (Cd)	control	No credible sovereign sets a numeric ceiling on element release from a metal or alloy food-contact article. Regulation (EU) 10/2011 governs plastics only; metals and alloys are a separate Regulation 1935/2004 Annex I material family for which the EU has adopted no specific measure, the US regulates food-contact substances without an element release ceiling, and Codex, FSANZ, Health Canada, the UK and Hong Kong set none. Testing is therefore mandatory on every certified lot with no invented ceiling: a limit borrowed from the plastics regulation would be a limit written for a different material family, and for an alloy surface the plastics nickel and aluminium values are not even achievable, so borrowing them would be an unfounded number rather than a stricter one. Cadmium in a food-contact metal article arrives from cadmium-bearing brazing fillers and from cadmium plating. The EU restricts both by content under REACH Annex XVII (Reg (EU) 494/2011), which is a percent-by-weight restriction and not a release ceiling; it is verified as a separate content obligation. For hollow-handle flatware the binding component is the handle-joint filler or solder, not the bowl alloy; for plated utensils it is the exposed substrate at a worn area.

Total arsenic (tAs)	control	No credible sovereign sets a numeric ceiling on element release from a metal or alloy food-contact article. Regulation (EU) 10/2011 governs plastics only; metals and alloys are a separate Regulation 1935/2004 Annex I material family for which the EU has adopted no specific measure, the US regulates food-contact substances without an element release ceiling, and Codex, FSANZ, Health Canada, the UK and Hong Kong set none. Testing is therefore mandatory on every certified lot with no invented ceiling: a limit borrowed from the plastics regulation would be a limit written for a different material family, and for an alloy surface the plastics nickel and aluminium values are not even achievable, so borrowing them would be an unfounded number rather than a stricter one. Arsenic is a residual impurity of copper and lead alloys and of some brasses and bronzes. It is determined as the total element; no food-contact instrument in the credible set states arsenic as a species. For hollow-handle flatware the binding component is the handle-joint filler or solder, not the bowl alloy; for plated utensils it is the exposed substrate at a worn area.

Inorganic arsenic (iAs)	control	Arsenic released from a metal or alloy surface is inorganic by construction, so an inorganic-arsenic determination cannot be lower than the total-arsenic result by any meaningful margin and cannot be bounded by a published total-arsenic number, because this row's total-arsenic cell is itself a control with no sovereign ceiling. A not-material determination is therefore not available here and the fail-safe applies: inorganic arsenic is a control, tested and escalated alongside total arsenic. No credible sovereign sets a numeric ceiling on element release from a metal or alloy food-contact article. Regulation (EU) 10/2011 governs plastics only; metals and alloys are a separate Regulation 1935/2004 Annex I material family for which the EU has adopted no specific measure, the US regulates food-contact substances without an element release ceiling, and Codex, FSANZ, Health Canada, the UK and Hong Kong set none. Testing is therefore mandatory on every certified lot with no invented ceiling: a limit borrowed from the plastics regulation would be a limit written for a different material family, and for an alloy surface the plastics nickel and aluminium values are not even achievable, so borrowing them would be an unfounded number rather than a stricter one.

Mercury, total (tHg)	control	No credible sovereign sets a numeric ceiling on element release from a metal or alloy food-contact article. Regulation (EU) 10/2011 governs plastics only; metals and alloys are a separate Regulation 1935/2004 Annex I material family for which the EU has adopted no specific measure, the US regulates food-contact substances without an element release ceiling, and Codex, FSANZ, Health Canada, the UK and Hong Kong set none. Testing is therefore mandatory on every certified lot with no invented ceiling: a limit borrowed from the plastics regulation would be a limit written for a different material family, and for an alloy surface the plastics nickel and aluminium values are not even achievable, so borrowing them would be an unfounded number rather than a stricter one. Mercury has no functional role in food-contact alloys and appears only as a trace impurity, but it is a mandatory panel cell and is determined as the total element on every food-contact component. For hollow-handle flatware the binding component is the handle-joint filler or solder, not the bowl alloy; for plated utensils it is the exposed substrate at a worn area.
Methylmercury (MeHg)	n/m	Methylmercury is formed by microbial methylation in aquatic food chains. A metal or alloy food-contact surface contains no organic matrix and no methylation pathway, and no credible sovereign sets a methylmercury requirement for any food-contact material. Total mercury is the governing determination for this row and remains a mandatory control; methylmercury is not material and never substitutes for it.

Nickel (Ni)	control	No credible sovereign sets a numeric ceiling on element release from a metal or alloy food-contact article. Regulation (EU) 10/2011 governs plastics only; metals and alloys are a separate Regulation 1935/2004 Annex I material family for which the EU has adopted no specific measure, the US regulates food-contact substances without an element release ceiling, and Codex, FSANZ, Health Canada, the UK and Hong Kong set none. Testing is therefore mandatory on every certified lot with no invented ceiling: a limit borrowed from the plastics regulation would be a limit written for a different material family, and for an alloy surface the plastics nickel and aluminium values are not even achievable, so borrowing them would be an unfounded number rather than a stricter one. Nickel release from austenitic stainless steel and from nickel-plated surfaces into acidic and saline food is a real, documented and material pathway, and it is exactly the pathway for which no sovereign ceiling exists. The EU plastics nickel SML of 0.02 mg/kg food is not applied here: it was written for a polymer surface and a bare stainless-steel surface does not meet it, so importing it would publish an unfounded number rather than a protective one. For hollow-handle flatware the binding component is the handle-joint filler or solder, not the bowl alloy; for plated utensils it is the exposed substrate at a worn area.

Tin (Sn)	control	No credible sovereign sets a numeric ceiling on element release from a metal or alloy food-contact article. Regulation (EU) 10/2011 governs plastics only; metals and alloys are a separate Regulation 1935/2004 Annex I material family for which the EU has adopted no specific measure, the US regulates food-contact substances without an element release ceiling, and Codex, FSANZ, Health Canada, the UK and Hong Kong set none. Testing is therefore mandatory on every certified lot with no invented ceiling: a limit borrowed from the plastics regulation would be a limit written for a different material family, and for an alloy surface the plastics nickel and aluminium values are not even achievable, so borrowing them would be an unfounded number rather than a stricter one. Tin release arrives from tinned linings, tinplate and tin-bearing solder. The sovereign tin numbers that exist are maximum levels on canned food, a FOOD basis on the contents rather than the article, and they are not published as this row's release ceiling. For hollow-handle flatware the binding component is the handle-joint filler or solder, not the bowl alloy; for plated utensils it is the exposed substrate at a worn area.

Aluminium (Al)	control	No credible sovereign sets a numeric ceiling on element release from a metal or alloy food-contact article. Regulation (EU) 10/2011 governs plastics only; metals and alloys are a separate Regulation 1935/2004 Annex I material family for which the EU has adopted no specific measure, the US regulates food-contact substances without an element release ceiling, and Codex, FSANZ, Health Canada, the UK and Hong Kong set none. Testing is therefore mandatory on every certified lot with no invented ceiling: a limit borrowed from the plastics regulation would be a limit written for a different material family, and for an alloy surface the plastics nickel and aluminium values are not even achievable, so borrowing them would be an unfounded number rather than a stricter one. Aluminium release from bare and anodised aluminium into acidic, saline and long-contact food is a real and documented pathway, and no sovereign sets a release ceiling for it. The EU plastics aluminium SML of 1 mg/kg food is not applied to an aluminium article: the instrument was written for plastics and did not contemplate an article whose food-contact surface is the element itself. For hollow-handle flatware the binding component is the handle-joint filler or solder, not the bowl alloy; for plated utensils it is the exposed substrate at a worn area.

Total chromium (Cr)	control	No credible sovereign sets a numeric ceiling on element release from a metal or alloy food-contact article. Regulation (EU) 10/2011 governs plastics only; metals and alloys are a separate Regulation 1935/2004 Annex I material family for which the EU has adopted no specific measure, the US regulates food-contact substances without an element release ceiling, and Codex, FSANZ, Health Canada, the UK and Hong Kong set none. Testing is therefore mandatory on every certified lot with no invented ceiling: a limit borrowed from the plastics regulation would be a limit written for a different material family, and for an alloy surface the plastics nickel and aluminium values are not even achievable, so borrowing them would be an unfounded number rather than a stricter one. Total chromium is retained as a screening determination for the alloy-release pathway rather than as a toxicological ceiling: chromium released from austenitic stainless steel is overwhelmingly chromium(III), which is the benign species, so a total-chromium number on this row would not be protective even if a sovereign had set one. The health-relevant determination is the hexavalent-chromium cell. For hollow-handle flatware the binding component is the handle-joint filler or solder, not the bowl alloy; for plated utensils it is the exposed substrate at a worn area.

Hexavalent chromium (Cr-VI)	control	Hexavalent chromium is the health-relevant chromium species and it cannot be dismissed on a metal article: chromate conversion coatings, passivation treatments and chromate-bearing pigments in interior printing are live sources, and hot alkaline conditions can oxidise chromium(III) at the surface. No credible sovereign sets a hexavalent-chromium release ceiling for a food-contact metal article, and this row's total-chromium cell is itself a control, so no published parent bounds this species and a speciation-bounded not-material determination is unavailable. The fail-safe applies. No credible sovereign sets a numeric ceiling on element release from a metal or alloy food-contact article. Regulation (EU) 10/2011 governs plastics only; metals and alloys are a separate Regulation 1935/2004 Annex I material family for which the EU has adopted no specific measure, the US regulates food-contact substances without an element release ceiling, and Codex, FSANZ, Health Canada, the UK and Hong Kong set none. Testing is therefore mandatory on every certified lot with no invented ceiling: a limit borrowed from the plastics regulation would be a limit written for a different material family, and for an alloy surface the plastics nickel and aluminium values are not even achievable, so borrowing them would be an unfounded number rather than a stricter one.

4 | Cite this standard

Pendergrass, K. "Metal utensils." In Heavy Metal Tested & Certified (HMTc) Food-Contact Consumer Goods and Kitchenware standard, version 1.0 (2026-08-17). Institute of Contaminant Standards (ICS), 2026.

STATUS AND LICENCE

Editorially reviewed in-house; no external peer review has been completed on this reference. Published as a preprint with

COMPETING INTERESTS

This briefing is published by the Heavy Metal Tested & Certified (HMTc) program, operated by the Institute of Contaminant Standards. Its statements about government

its review state tracked on the article page. Released under CC BY 4.0.

DATA AVAILABILITY

The works this reference draws on are listed in full in the references above and on the briefing page at https://heavymetalcertified.com/standards/utensils-metal. Primary legal instruments and expert-body assessments are named with their public identifiers; the underlying occurrence and toxicology corpus is maintained on the Heavy Metal Index.

regulations, toxicology, and occurrence are sourced to the cited primary and expert-body records and to the independently maintained Heavy Metal Index; the program's own certification thresholds are not used as evidence for any factual claim made here.

PUBLICATION HISTORY

This revision 2026-08. The full dated record is maintained at https://heavymetalcertified.com/standards/utensils-metal.